excitement and anticipation.

The first Pakistani player I met was Aamer Sohail, the aggressive left-hander, in the lobby of the hotel we were put up in. Sohail would become the first teammate to bond and connect with me. (It's a pity that in the years that followed, he'd become the first Pakistan player I'd have a falling-out with.)

Next, near the elevators, I bumped into Saqlain Mushtaq, one of the younger guys in the squad. I had no idea that day that over the years, we would become great friends, even competitors. Soon after, I met Wasim (Akram) bhai. Even today, my first impression of him is extremely positive: What a guy! What a great leader! What a towering and benevolent man! On that first day with the team, I had no inkling of how important a role he would play in my career, how he would become my biggest mentor, both on and off the field.

Everybody I met was very welcoming, especially Moin (Khan) bhai, who would eventually become my yardstick of morale and teambuilding. He has a lot of *rakh rakhao*, as we call it: the desi ability to be a proper gentleman. He became my first true friend in the team. Of course, the friendly, buddy vibe developed over time. But on that first day, I was star-struck. Everybody around me was a star. In fact, all members of that team – Saeed Anwar (captain), Saleem Elahi, Ijaz Ahmed, Ramiz Raja, Saleem Malik, Moin Khan, Saqlain Mushtaq, Waqar Younis, Shahid Nazir and others – were superstars. The current Pakistan team, in 2019, has just one or two. That Pakistan team, in 1996, was full of them.

The best part, however, was that I wasn't scared or nervous about being on the big stage anymore. Nor was I underconfident. I stopped being a bundle of nerves, even though I thought I'd be one when I'd meet my teammates. Moreover, everything happened so quickly that I forgot to wear the Pakistan blazer – in fact, there had been no time to get one stitched. I was still wearing my U-19 jacket. And yet, there I was, part of one of the greatest teams ever to play the great game.

Also, for the record, I was just nineteen, and not sixteen like they claim. I was born in 1975. So, yes, the authorities stated my age incorrectly.

When I got to meet the rest of the squad, surprisingly, everybody was warm. The seniors – Moin Khan, Wasim Akram, Ramiz Raja – were very caring in a do-you-need-anything kind of way. They saw me during practice; it was the first time they all saw me bat. They backed me up, cheered me on and gave me great tactical advice. At the time, Saqlain Mushtaq was also a newcomer in the team. So was Azhar Mahmood. I adjusted quickly with the younger guys. The fear factor quickly vanished into a manageable comfort zone. Being the youngest was actually an advantage. My roommate on that tour of Kenya was the classy leftie, Shadab Kabir. We had some good times together.

Closer to match day for my debut, the nets started. I remember when they told me to pad up. I couldn't believe what started happening. I faced Wiqi bhai (Waqar Younis), Wasim bhai, even the first-class legend, Saqlain Mushtaq, and pounded them away on all sides of the nets. My shots were big and natural, and came hard and quick. I had switched on my batting and had switched off any edgy nerves.

My famous century's roots lie in those nets sessions. Here's a confession: all bowlers really like to bat. I was inducted into the national side as a bowler and was really looking forward to batting in the nets. In fact, I thought it was the only batting I'd get on the tour. So when the nets started, I